



The Mer de Glace

A glacier on the northern, or French, side of Mont Blanc, notable for the spectacular banding pattern on its surface

The Mer de Glace is a valley glacier—a long glacier with mountains on both sides—that extends down from the Mont Blanc Massif toward the Chamonix Valley in eastern France. It is some 7 miles (11 km) long.

The Mer de Glace, “Sea of Ice,” gets its name from the undulating, banded pattern seen on part of the glacier below an icefall (a steeply descending section) situated at an altitude of around 10,500 ft (3,200 m). This surface pattern has been described as waves frozen in the midst of a storm. The “waves” are actually alternating bands of thicker, lighter ice and thinner, darker ice, created due to seasonal factors (see panel, right). The bands, known as ogives, are curved—the result of the ice in the middle of the glacier moving downhill slightly faster than the ice at its sides.

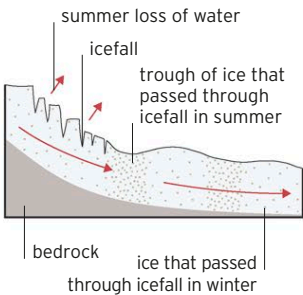
▽ **SLAKING DOWNWARD**

The Mer de Glace descends some 8,200 ft (2,500 m) vertically from its ice accumulation area, which lies below Mont Blanc, visible here at top left, to its snout.



**THE MER DE GLACE'S
BANDING PATTERN**

In summer, ice passing down the icefall loses volume by melting, and forms a trough at the bottom, darkened by the concentration of dust inside it. In winter, thicker and lighter-looking ice emerges at the bottom.



△ **ICY HIGHWAY**

Dark medial moraines (longitudinal stripes) run down the glacier, reinforcing the appearance of a winding highway of ice.

TYPES OF MORaine

Debris carried along by a glacier and later deposited is called a moraine. Lateral moraines occur at the sides of a glacier, whereas medial moraines form from smaller glaciers merging. Subglacial moraines are found at the base, and englacial moraines are trapped within the ice. A terminal moraine (not shown here) is rock material dropped at the melting snout of a glacier.

